

2026 Student Competition Brief

Presented by the U of T Transportation Alumni Network

This year's theme is: Congestion Pricing for Transportation Demand Management

Trucks trapped on the 401, buses backed up on Steeles Avenue, and cars crawling along the Skyway Bridge - what do these things have in common? Whether you think it affects you or not, transportation congestion "costs the Greater Toronto and Hamilton Area (GTHA) more than \$44 billion a year in economic and social value" ([CBC News, Jan 29, 2025](#)). Congestion pricing has been proposed as a solution to this problem, based on examples in London, Singapore, New York, and elsewhere in the world. But how could congestion pricing work in or around Toronto?

This year, we invite you to brief our judges on how congestion pricing could work in the GTHA. You are welcome to explore congestion pricing in any part of the GTHA from any angle. Locations to charge, toll structures, technologies for collecting tolls, or even how congestion pricing relates to non-auto modes could all be potential topics. Regardless of the angle, it is critical for your team to speak to the social equity implications of your solution.

How Does it Work?

Form a team of 2-3 students (undergraduate and/or graduate, including those graduating in Spring 2026) to undertake a transportation research project, generate recommendations applicable to industry practitioners, and compete for a chance to win monetary prizes. This competition is open to students of all programs; interdisciplinary teams are encouraged.

Receive mentorship from industry professionals, write a briefing note, and pitch your recommendations at the annual Symposium to an audience of industry judges, fellow students, and alumni working in transportation.

Competition prizes:

- **First Place Team:** \$500 per student
- **Second Place Team:** \$400 per student
- **Third Place Team:** \$300 per student

What Will You Do?

Teams will undertake original research over a two month period to generate recommendations. Work must be original research (i.e. not work submitted for another class or competition).

Research methods may include best practice review, data analysis, scenario evaluation, policy analysis, and site analysis. **Research must include at least two interviews with professionals.**¹ Professionals may include the assigned mentors, transportation industry professionals, and academics.

¹ Due to research ethics protocol, surveys, interviews, and focus groups may only be conducted with industry stakeholders/professionals and not members of the general public.

Deliverables consist of a briefing note and a briefing presentation, which should be tailored for an audience of “senior decision-makers” in the field of transportation:

- **Briefing Note:** A maximum 6-page (double spaced, 11-point font, PDF format) briefing note including an executive summary, recommendations, problem statement, methodology, and analysis. A reference list and/or appendices may be included in addition to the 6 page briefing note.
- **Briefing Presentation:** A 12-minute PowerPoint presentation (plus 3 minutes of Q&A) summarizing research findings and recommendations, to be pitched at the Symposium.

Each team will be scored based on their Briefing Note (30%) and their Briefing Presentation (70%) by a panel of industry judges. Competition winners will be announced at the Symposium following the presentations.

Please note that AI tools (ChatGPT, Copilot, etc.) may not be used to prepare your briefing note or presentation. Teams are allowed to use AI tools to support their research as long as they clearly indicate in their briefing note where and how these tools were used.

How to Apply?

Applying is easy! Each interested team needs to provide a two page application describing their interest in the competition, proposed research title and a brief description of the topic, potential interviewees, and an overview of the team (including programs of study).²

Please email your application to UTTAlumniNetwork@gmail.com by **11:59 pm on July 3rd, 2026** with all team members CC'd. The UTTAN committee will review applications and provide an update within one week.

Need help finding a team? Leave your contact information and topic ideas [in this spreadsheet!](#)

Key 2026 Competition Dates

- **Friday Jul. 3rd:** Submit proposals
- **Friday Jul. 10th:** Short-listed teams / mentors announced
- **Friday Sep. 4th:** Submit briefing notes and team headshots
- **Monday Sep. 21st:** Submit presentation and presentation dry run (virtual meeting)
- **Late September:** Symposium and awards night (in-person, to be scheduled)

About UTTAN

The University of Toronto Transportation Alumni Network (UTTAN) is an association of U of T graduates of any discipline, working as transportation professionals. We welcome you to join the Alumni Network and to participate in this 8th annual UTTAN student competition.

² By submitting an application and participating in the competition, teams agree to their research findings and briefing notes being published and/or shared by UTTAN and used as sample submissions for future years.

